The previous constitution, drafted in 1971, included an identical article. It originally proclaimed *shari'a* to be only "a" source of legislation, not "the" source, but Mubarak had it amended in 1980 to placate Islamists. Morsi went a step further. He added Article 219, which tried to define the "principles of *shari'a*", a concept that had been left intentionally vague in previous constitutions. The amendment was pushed by salafi politicians, ultraconservative Muslims who were both allies and rivals of the Muslim Brotherhood. Its wording was highly technical, largely unintelligible to anyone without a background in Islamic jurisprudence. Suffice it to say, though, that the article would have changed the way Egyptian judges and legislators interpreted the law, restricting their previously freewheeling and dismissive approach to the "principles of *shari'a*".

Yuval Diskin, a former Shin Bet chief, drew the parallel in a thoughtful Facebook post in November. Both the Egyptian and Israeli laws, he argued, were the start of a "slippery slope", an effort aimed at "creating a large and significant crack that will bring out the opposite of democracy… by setting the order of priority for the values that will guide the courts, and in fact our life."[10]

For Netanyahu, as ever, the decision had more to do with politics than ideology. He had never tried to promote such a law before 2014. But his right-wing coalition partners saw it as an opportunity to advance a longtime goal. "If the bill doesn't pass, we don't have a coalition; everything will fall apart," Bennett warned. He said in a Facebook video that the bill was needed to block the Supreme Court's looming effort "to apply the law of return to non-Jews" and open the floodgates to mass immigration, something that was not, in fact, happening.

The cabinet convened in early December to vote on a vague "statement of principles", which endorsed the legislation and urged the Knesset to reconcile the various drafts into a single bill. Netanyahu also put his liberal coalition partners on notice. "I hear ultimatums, *diktat* and threats of quitting from various parts of the coalition. A country cannot be run this way," he warned.

Indeed, it could not. A stormy four-hour debate ensued, closed to the press, but raucous enough that reporters gathered outside heard lawmakers banging on tables and shouting at each other. The bill was eventually approved, 15–6; the dissenting votes came from center-left members of the coalition. Netanyahu fired Lapid and Tzipi Livni the following week, after